PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Dodge Ramcharger (first generation)

1974–1980 · Ramcharger · Plymouth Trail Duster · Removable top

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust: wheel wells, floors and the radiator support**
  Ramcharger Central members list the rear wheel wells, lower sills and fenders, the bottom of the radiator support, the floors (especially the driver's side and the rear floor), the rain gutters and the windshield surround. Also look under the battery and at the bottoms of the doors. One desert truck still needed metal in the core support. Bring a magnet.

- [ ] **Find out which 4WD system it really has**
  From 1974 to 1979 the truck should have a full-time NP203 and a front axle with no hubs. If you see locking hubs, a part-time conversion kit or a different transfer case, ask what was changed. Ramcharger Central's SuperBurban warns that the NP203's park pawl only holds when the front axle is engaged or the case is in Loc. A converted truck with unlocked hubs can roll away in Park.

- [ ] **Shake the front wheels**
  On a forum thread about a full-time 1978 Dodge, one experienced owner calls the full-time front hub bearings 'the weak spot in these trucks from day one'. They were sealed for life until a grease fitting was added in 1976, and few owners ever greased them. Jack up each front wheel and rock it top to bottom. You want zero play. Wide tires on big-offset wheels wear these bearings faster.

- [ ] **Steering box mount and wander**
  Ramcharger Central members say the stock steering box mounting plate is prone to cracking. Dodge made the plate thicker in 1988, and members recommend the 1977–93 box design as an upgrade for earlier trucks. Check for cracks around the box and the frame rail, and for wandering steering. NHTSA's 1978 recalls covered the intermediate shaft's pot coupling and a misindexed lower shaft, so ask whether the recall work was done.

- [ ] **Is the engine the one it was born with?**
  These trucks get re-engined constantly. Bring a Trailer has sold first-gen trucks with 340, 383 and 408 V8s, a Cummins 6BT and even a 1974 Trail Duster body on a 1992 Ramcharger chassis. A window sticker or build sheet is gold. The 440 was 4×4-only, the six wasn't sold in California, and the big-blocks were gone after 1978.

- [ ] **Big-block heat**
  A 440 in a short truck runs hot. The seller of a 1976 Ramcharger on BaT reported overheating at idle in hot weather. A Ramcharger Central member with a 440 trail truck fought constant overheating and low oil pressure at high rpm until he pulled the engine. Look for an upgraded radiator, a working fan shroud and a temperature gauge that stays put in traffic.

- [ ] **The roof, the doors and their seals**
  Make sure a removable hardtop is actually there and fits. A truck built before June 10, 1974 with half doors needs its matching roof, because the door pillars are part of it. Hardtop rear-glass weatherstrip is a known chore. Ramcharger Central members use the factory rope trick or work it in with stiff plastic.

- [ ] **Odometers and titles**
  Five-digit odometers roll over, and many BaT listings describe true mileage as unknown. Read the title too. Listings have shown Classic and 'Exceeds Limits' brands, and liens. Service records and original paperwork are worth real money in this market.

YEARS TO KNOW

1978	RECALL	Two steering recalls: a misindexed steering column (77V176) and an intermediate-shaft pot coupling that might not tighten (78V038).
1980	RECALL	NHTSA campaign 84V115 adds a fuel-tank skid plate because the rear step bumper failed the FMVSS 301 impact test.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Steering column misassembled, steering wheel indexed 180° off**
  1978 · NHTSA 77V176000
- [ ] **Intermediate steering shaft pot coupling may not tighten**
  1978 · NHTSA 78V038000
- [ ] **Rear step bumper may not protect the fuel tank in a rear impact**
  1980 · NHTSA 84V115000

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **First gen vs second gen**
  1974–80 trucks have a removable steel top, or none at all, on the 1972-style Dodge truck body. From 1981 the roof is welded on, the liftgate is fiberglass, and the sheet metal and dash are new (Ramcharger Central).
- [ ] **Year by nose**
  1977–78 grilles have rectangular parking lamps. For 1979 the hood, grille and headlights are all new, with quad rectangular lamps on the upper trims and two round lamps on the lower ones. The 1980 grille openings are painted black (Ramcharger Central). Grilles swap easily, so check them against the title and the VIN.
- [ ] **Half doors (early 1974)**
  Trucks built before June 10, 1974 have doors with no frame above the glass. The window frames belong to the removable roof. Later trucks use normal pickup doors (Wikipedia).
- [ ] **Full-time hardware**
  A stock 1974–79 4×4 has the NP203 with five lever positions (Low Loc, Low, Neutral, High, High Loc) and a front axle with no locking hubs. Locking hubs, drive flanges or a different transfer case mean the drivetrain has been changed.

- [ ] **Chassis numbers**
  On BaT-listed trucks, 4×4 Dodges begin A10 and Trail Dusters AA0. The sixth character is the model-year digit. The fifth character matches the engine on those trucks: E on a 1974 318, F on 1977–78 360s and D on 1976–77 440s. Confirm with a proper decoder or the build paperwork before you trust it.

- [ ] **Trims and packages**
  SE (cloth-and-vinyl buckets, woodgrain trim and a lockable console with a removable beverage chest; from 1975 the SE dash adds volt and vacuum gauges). The 1978 Four by Four had the Macho package, with graphics, spoke or chrome wheels, 10-15LT tires and power steering. Also Top Hand, the Sno-Commander factory plow package (4×4 only) and, at Plymouth, the Trail Duster Sport.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/ramcharger/ramcharger-1st/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks